

Out of Africa

Our species—modern humans, or *Homo sapiens*—evolved in Africa around 300,000 years ago. Yet it took more than 100,000 years before we began to leave the continent and spread across other parts of the world. Traveling mostly on foot, and later by boat, modern humans eventually settled almost every part of the planet.

The journey out of Africa was made possible due to changes in the climate. Around 194,000 years ago (YA), a warm, wet period turned the previously impassable Sinai Desert (the region linking Africa and Asia) into a green and fertile strip of land, allowing people to move there from Egypt. The descendants of those who took this route gradually died out as the climate became dry again.

Much later, during the Ice Age about 80,000 years ago, low sea levels enabled people to wade across the shallow Red Sea and reach the

Arabian Peninsula in western Asia.

At first, they spread east, keeping only to the warmer regions. Around 50,000 years ago, people began to settle, and make the earliest forms of art and music. They also invented new technologies, such as needles and the harpoon (a hunting weapon), and tamed the first dogs.

The ability to survive and adapt to colder climates allowed *Homo sapiens* to move further north, and later reach Europe and the Americas. By around 13,000 BCE, humans had spread into every continent except Antarctica.

TAILORED CLOTHING ►

Modern humans as well as Neanderthals, an earlier human species, used animal skin for clothing. While Neanderthals wore skins loosely tied around them, modern humans invented bone needles (right), with which they could sew tailored clothes, and even decorate them with objects such as beads.



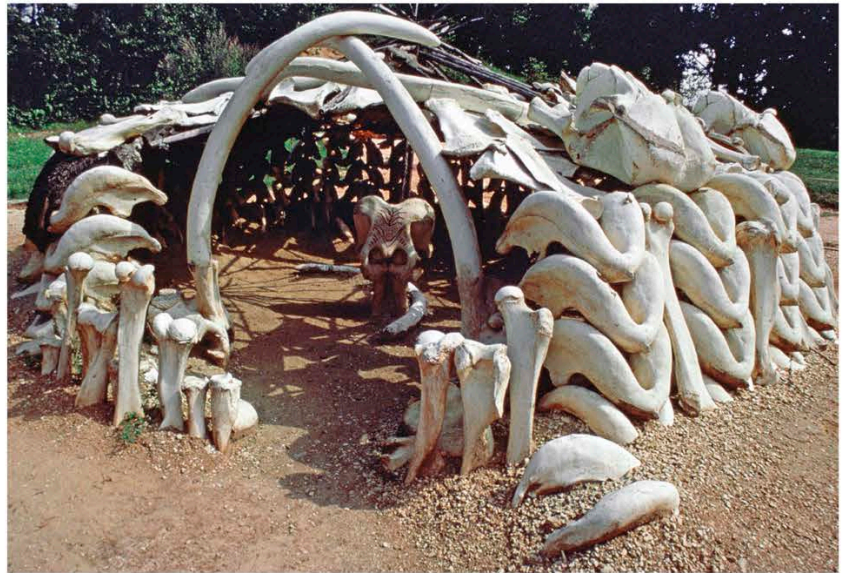
◄ SETTLING AUSTRALIA

Low sea levels allowed modern humans to move down through Southeast Asia into Australia around 65,000 years ago. These first settlers came across many unfamiliar plants and animals, such as kangaroos and giant flightless birds. They hunted them using wooden spears and curved throwing sticks known as boomerangs (left).



MAMMOTH HUT ►

Wherever modern humans went, they were able to build shelters, even where there was no wood. During the Ice Age, people hunted mammoths on the treeless plains of Europe and Asia, and built shelters using their bones covered with hides (skins).



MODERN HUMANS

194,000–65,000 YA

Modern humans leave Africa and move into Asia. The first wave follows a northern route via modern-day Israel and the next one a southern route via Arabia.

65,000 YA

People make the first known sea voyage—a 56-mile (90-km) journey to Australia—perhaps using bamboo rafts.



45,000 YA

Modern humans begin making the first art. The oldest known animal cave painting so far is that of a pig in Indonesia.

PREHISTORIC CAVE
PAINTING